

# Attitude reports: From modal logic to event semantics

*Day 4: How many attitudes?*

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# The picture so far

## **Day 2:** Hintikka: attitudes as modals

- ✦ Primary difference among attitudes is which set of worlds they quantify over

## **Day 3:** Kratzer-Moulton-Elliott: attitudes as event predicates

- ✦ Primary difference among language is in the metalanguage predicates in their denotation (*believe'* vs. *want'*)

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- ❖ Not a theory of what the *concept* of believing, wanting, etc. consists of
- ❖ But this aspect of meaning is both interesting and relevant
- ❖ Instance of a more general lack of attention in formal sem. to lexical semantics
- ❖ **Today:** Motivating a dive into the conceptual component of meaning

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But *which* do some attitudes get expressed using the ‘same’ verb in some languages and *why*? What is ‘basic’?

**What attitudes even are there?**

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As languages change, where do new distinctions get formed/collapsed?

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What attitudes do(n't) languages have words for, and why?

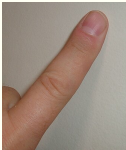
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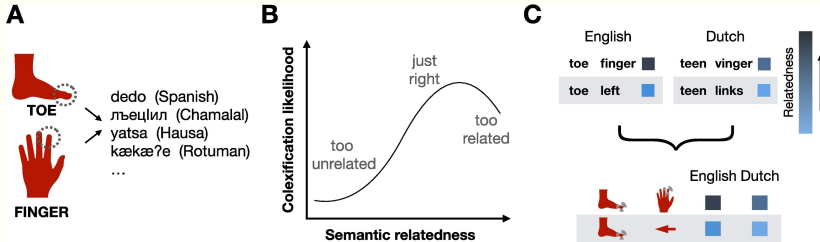
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But it is not a free-for-all:

|                    |                                                                                   |                                                                                   |                                                                                    |                                                                                     |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                    |  |  |  |  |
| Language           |                                                                                   |                                                                                   |                                                                                    |                                                                                     |
| <b>English</b>     | hand                                                                              | arm                                                                               | finger                                                                             | toe                                                                                 |
| <b>Catalan</b>     | mà                                                                                | braç                                                                              | dit                                                                                |                                                                                     |
| <b>Estonian</b>    | käsi                                                                              |                                                                                   | sõrm                                                                               | varvas                                                                              |
| <b>Hawaiian</b>    | lima                                                                              |                                                                                   | manamana                                                                           |                                                                                     |
| <b>Unattested?</b> | <i>hand</i>                                                                       | <i>arm-finger</i>                                                                 |                                                                                    | <i>toe</i>                                                                          |

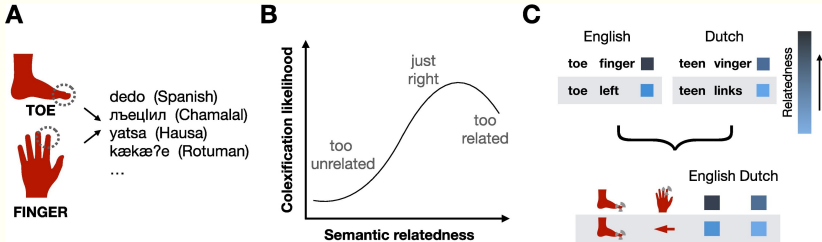
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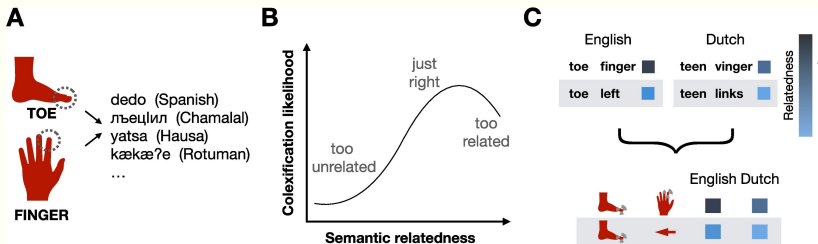
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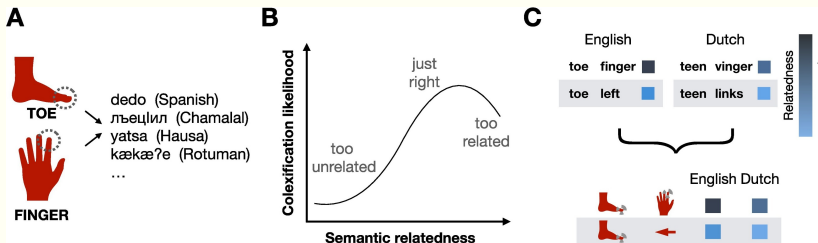


Why is it bad to be *too related*?

- ✚ Monday vs. Tuesday
- ✚ rabbit vs. hare

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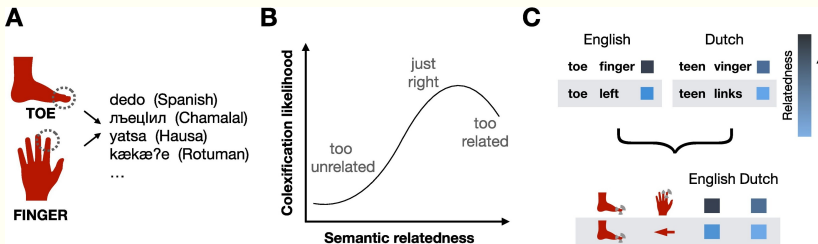
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How to measure relatedness?

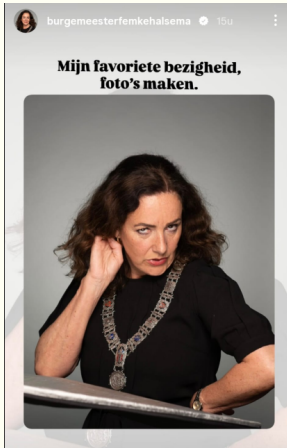
- ❖ Distributional similarity
- ❖ Human judgments

# Two kinds of *knowing*

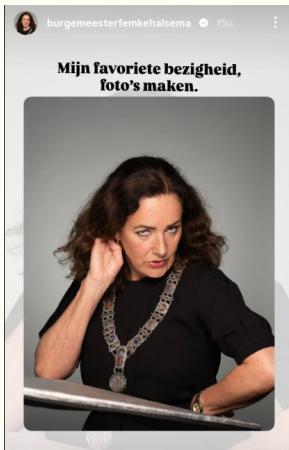
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## English

- a. I **know** that the mayor of Amsterdam likes taking pictures.
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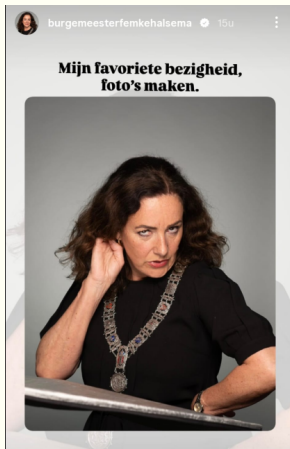
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## Dutch

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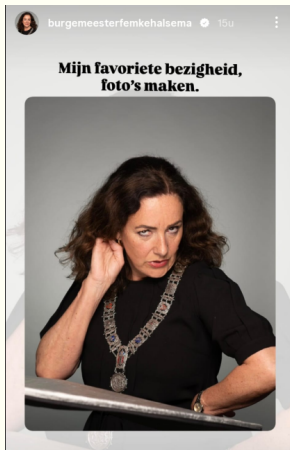
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## French

- a. Je **sais** que la maire d'Amsterdam aime prendre des photos.
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(See also: Djärv 2023)

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- (5) I'm thinking that I should adopt a dachshund.  
≈ I believe weakly/suppose/deduce/etc. that I should adopt a dachshund.
- (5) I'm thinking whether I should adopt a dachshund.  
≈ I'm weighing the possibility of adopting a dachshund or not

# Think-want-hope polysemy

**Navajo** (Bogal-Allbritten 2016)

- (6) a. Nahattin            **nisin.**  
         AREALS.rain.IMP 1SG.NISIN.IMP  
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'I think it is raining.'
- b. Nahodoottjįt        **nisin.**  
AREALS.rain.FUT 1SG.NISIN.IMP  
'I want it to rain.' (**Not:** 'I think it will rain.')
- c. Alice nahótąą'        lágo        **nizin.**  
Alice AREALS.rain.OPT hope.not 3S.NISIN.IMPF  
'Alice hopes it will not rain.'

# Think-want-hope-allow for-...

**Koryak** (Močnik & Abramovitz 2019)

- (7) a. meλλo **kivəŋ**, (əno) kumuqetəŋ  
Melljo ATT.3SG.PRES that rain.3SG.PRES  
'Melljo {says, thinks, allows, hopes, fears} that it is raining.'
- b. meλλo **kivəŋ**, (iwke) nəʔəmuqetən  
Melljo ATT.3SG.PRES if.only rain.3SG.CF  
'Melljo wishes it would rain'

!!!M&A: Koryak *ivək* can vary in both force **and** flavor!

# Shameless data collection

Can you think of attitudes in your language(s) that either:

- ✦ Both map onto the same word of English, or
- ✦ Does not make a distinction that *is* made in English?

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- ✦ Limited evidence for attitude predicates that can also vary in force (Koryak)
- ✦ Few (but more than zero) attitude verbs lexicalize existential/possibility force
- ✦ The ‘conceptual space’ of attitudes is still being mapped out
- ✦ **Finale:** One more ‘impossible’ verb...or is it?